In an age when artists are expected to feed the algorithms by consistently dropping new material every few weeks, it might seem that the 11 years it took electronic music duo MIDIval Punditz to follow up their last album, 2015's *Light*, with their recently-released fifth full-length effort, *Love and Machines*, was a bad career move. Yet it may be the very reason they're still together.

Composer-producers and high-school friends Gaurav Raina and Tapan Raj formed MIDIval Punditz in 1997, which makes them one of the longest-running Indian independent music acts around. The reason behind their longevity is that "we allow each other the time to evolve and do other things", says Raj. "We fully support each other's aspirations outside [of the duo]. Once we're done with those, we come back to being the Punditz. Then, we treat it quite sacredly. In some other acts that have fallen apart, [venturing] outside the band has become a point of friction."

Over the past decade—during which they've put out a handful of singles—Raina has turned his attention to composing scores and soundtracks for web series such as *Made in Heaven* and *Dabba Cartel* with singer-songwriter Tarana Marwah aka Komorebi, whom he married in 2025. Raj has focused on his career as a DJ, playing residencies at clubs in their home city of Delhi and simultaneously building startups in the enterprise software space.

In the interim, they never stopped making music, and constantly sent each other tracks they thought could work for MIDIval Punditz. "The desire to make an album never goes away," Raina says. "I guess we're old-school like that." When they had about eight tunes in total, they decided it was time to record the LP. *Love and Machines* is a familiar yet fresh collection that adds a few new flourishes to their signature blend of electronic music with Indian folk, semi-classical and Sufi elements.

The difference this time around was that their solo work naturally influenced the sound. "Tapan, because of his rise in the DJ space, has got a stronger sense of fast rhythms and dance floor vibe [and my] going into OTT has made my composition a little more emotional," says Raina. These changes "were more than welcome", he adds. "Because it's just who we are, right? How else does music have individuality, if not that of the individuals themselves? To be able to capture that honestly was the intention of this album."

Fittingly, the featured artists on *Love and Machines* are a mix of both old and new collaborators. Among those they reunite with are folk singer Malini Awasthi, who appears on the trippy 'Jogi' and drum and bass cut 'Koyaliya', and Papon, who returns on the poignant ballad 'Na Jaaney Kyun'. Singers that finally make their debut on a MIDIval



BLENT FORMS *Love and Machines* infuses Indian folk, semi-classical and Sufi elements to the act's electronic signature sound